

tabtabtab — User Guide

tabtabtab

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1 Introduction

A faster, smarter command palette for [Foundry's Nuke](#) — replaces the built-in Tab menu with anchored fuzzy search, per-category colour blocks, node icons, and instant access to every menu item in Nuke.

1.1 Why tabtabtab instead of Nuke's built-in Tab menu?

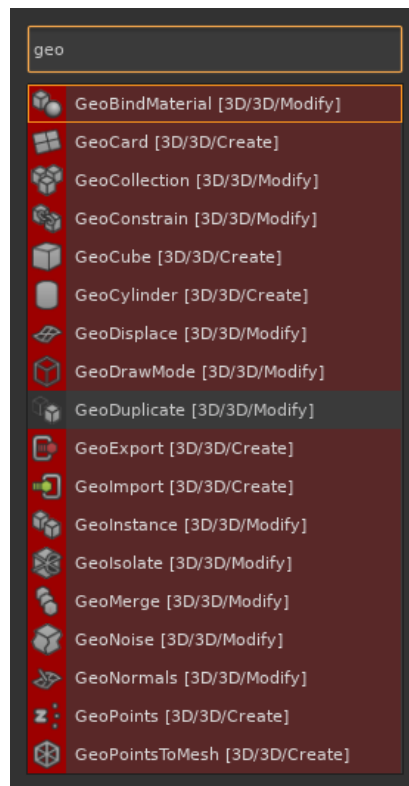
Feature	tabtabtab	Nuke built-in
Anchored fuzzy matching ("blr" → Blur)	Yes	No — matches anywhere, so "blr" returns dozens of unrelated results
Finds menu items (e.g. File > Exit)	Yes	No — nodes only
Per-category colour blocks	Yes	No
Node icons in results	Yes	No
Keyboard shortcuts in results	Yes	No
Usage-weighted ranking	Yes	Yes — but displays the weight number, which is redundant since ordering already reflects it

Anchored fuzzy matching is the key difference. When you type "blr", tabtabtab matches "Blur" because the letters appear in order from the start of a word. Nuke's built-in menu uses non-anchored matching, which returns every item that contains those letters anywhere — usually dozens of irrelevant results for short queries.

Menu items, not just nodes. Type "exit" and tabtabtab shows "File > Exit". Type "pref" and it shows "Edit > Preferences". No more mousing through the menu bar.

1.2 Screenshots

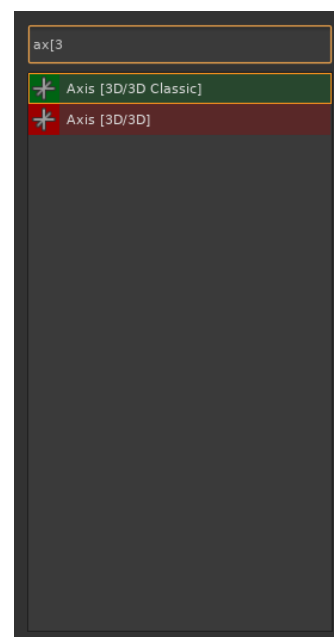
Node icons in the left column and colour-coded rows by node category:



Palette with node icons and colour blocks

Category search — type `[` to include the category tag in your search (`ax[3` → Axis [3D]):

Menu items appear alongside nodes — type `anch` to find Edit > Anchors commands:

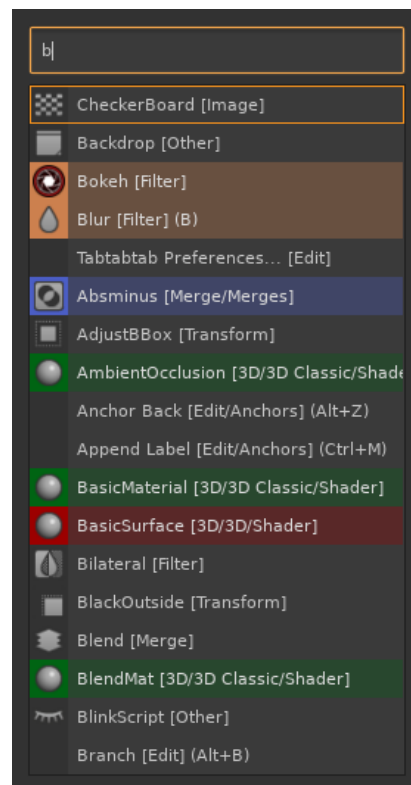


Category search using the `[` prefix

Non-anchored search (leading space) — matches letters anywhere in the name:



Palette showing menu items



Non-anchored search results

1.3 Search modes

The table below shows the *default* space-prefix → mode mapping. The mapping is configurable; see [Preferences](#) to remap which mode is triggered by each space level.

Prefix	Default behaviour
(none)	Anchored fuzzy match. Each character of your query must appear in order, starting from the beginning of the node name. "blr" matches "Blur" but not "ColorBurn".
one space	Non-anchored fuzzy match. Characters must appear in order anywhere in the name. " blr" matches both "Blur" and "ColorBurn".
two spaces	Non-anchored consecutive substring. The exact run of letters must appear somewhere in the name. " blur" matches "MotionBlur" but not "Blur2".
[	Include the category tag in the search. "ax[3d" narrows results to items whose category contains "3d", e.g. "Axis [3D]". Without [, the category tag is ignored.

1.3.1 Space-prefix repeat behaviour

After you create a node, tabtabtab pre-fills the search field with a leading space followed by the node's display name (for example, " Blur [Filter]"). The next time you press Tab to open the palette, that text is already in the field. Press Tab again without typing anything and the same node is created immediately — no searching required.

The leading space is intentional: it enables non-anchored matching so the full display name (which includes the category tag) matches correctly against itself.

1.4 Keyboard shortcuts

Key	Action
Tab or Enter	Create the selected item
Up / Down arrows	Navigate the result list
Escape	Close without creating

Ctrl+Tab still opens Nuke's built-in tab menu.

1.5 Your first node — a 60-second tour

Once installed, this is the whole workflow:

1. *Open the palette.* Hover over the Node Graph and press *Tab*.
2. *Type a few letters.* Try `blr`. tabtabtab uses ANCHORED matching, so `blr` jumps straight to *Blur* — the letters match in order from the start of the word.
3. *Pick a result.* Use *Up / Down* to move through the list. The colour block on the left and the node icon tell you the category at a glance.
4. *Create it.* Press *Enter* (or *Tab* again) to drop the selected node into your graph. Press *Escape* to back out without creating anything.

1.5.1 Now do the thing the built-in menu can't: find COMMANDS, not just nodes

This is the feature that makes tabtabtab worth installing. Nuke's built-in Tab menu only finds nodes — to run a menu command you have to hunt through the menu bar with the mouse. tabtabtab searches *every menu item in Nuke* the same way it searches nodes:

1. Press *Tab* to open the palette.
2. Type `exit` → tabtabtab surfaces *File > Exit*. Press *Enter* to run it.
3. Try `pref` → *Edit > Preferences*. Or `anch` → the *Edit > Anchors* commands. Or the name of any command buried three menus deep.

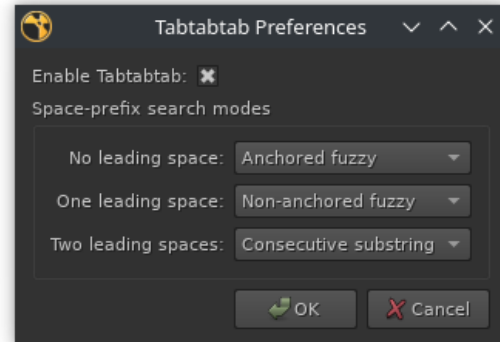
Anything you'd normally click through the menu bar to reach is now one Tab and a few keystrokes away — that's the real upgrade over the built-in menu.

1.5.2 A few more things to try

- *Repeat the last node instantly.* After creating a node, press *Tab Tab* (open the palette, then Tab again without typing) and the same node is recreated. The field is pre-filled with the last node's name, so a second Tab just confirms it.
 - *Search anywhere in the name.* Start your query with a leading space (`blr`) to match letters anywhere in the name instead of only from the start. See [Search modes](#) for all the prefixes.
-

1.6 Preferences

Open *Edit > Tabtabtab Preferences...* to access the preferences dialog.



Tabtabtab Preferences dialog

- *Enable tabtabtab* — uncheck to disable the plugin and restore Nuke’s default Tab behaviour. Changes take effect immediately without restarting Nuke.
- *Space-prefix search modes* — assign which search mode is triggered by zero, one, or two leading spaces. Each of the three modes (Anchored fuzzy, Non-anchored fuzzy, Consecutive substring) must be assigned to exactly one space level. Defaults match the [Search modes](#) table above.

1.7 Troubleshooting

Pressing Tab does nothing / the old Nuke menu appears.

- Make sure the palette is enabled in *Edit > Tabtabtab Preferences...* (the *Enable tabtabtab* checkbox).
- Confirm the plugin actually loaded. Open the Nuke Script Editor and check the output, or start Nuke from a terminal — `menu.py` prints a traceback there if registration failed.
- Press Tab while the mouse is over the *Node Graph*. Tab is context-sensitive in Nuke and only opens the palette in the Node Graph pane.
- `Ctrl+Tab` always opens Nuke’s built-in tab menu, so you can fall back to it any time.

The "Tabtabtab Preferences..." item isn't in the Edit menu.

This means `menu.py` didn’t run — almost always a file-placement problem. See the next item.

It worked before I installed this, but now another ~/.nuke tool is broken (or vice versa).

Nuke runs the `menu.py` in each directory on `NUKE_PATH`. The usual cause is overwriting an existing `~/.nuke/menu.py` when copying the files in. Fix it one of two ways:

- Put the tabtabtab files in their *own folder* on `NUKE_PATH` (e.g. `~/.nuke/tabtabtab/`), so its `menu.py` doesn’t collide with any other. This is the recommended layout.
- Or, if you must keep everything in one `~/.nuke/menu.py`, paste the contents of tabtabtab’s `menu.py` into your existing one rather than replacing the file.

Nodes I use constantly aren't ranked first.

Ranking is usage-weighted and learns over time — see [Weighting](#). Newly installed, every node starts equal; the order improves as you create nodes. Weights persist in `~/.nuke/tabtabtab_weights.json`; delete that file to reset ranking.

Results show no colour blocks.

Nodes whose tile colour is Nuke's global default (no class-specific colour) are intentionally shown without a colour block. See [Colour blocks](#).

1.8 Weighting

Each time you create a node, its usage weight increases. Higher-weighted nodes appear earlier in results when multiple items match your query. Weights are saved to `~/.nuke/tabtabtab_weights.json` between sessions.

1.9 Colour blocks

Each result row is tinted with the node's tile colour as defined in Nuke:

- The left column shows a solid colour block at full opacity (the node's tile colour).
- The row background receives a semi-transparent wash of the same colour (~31% opacity).
- Text colour adjusts automatically for legibility (dark text on bright backgrounds, light text on dark backgrounds).

Nodes whose tile colour is the Nuke global default (no class-specific colour) are shown without colour blocks.

1.10 Compatibility

- *Nuke 13 and later* (PySide2)
- *Nuke 15 and later* (PySide6)

Both Qt bindings are supported. The correct one is selected automatically at import time.

1.11 License

Released into the public domain under [The Unlicense](#). Do whatever you like with it.

1.12 Attribution

tabtabtab is based on [dbr/tabtabtab](#) by dbr, which appears to be no longer maintained. This fork extends the original with multi-monitor support, visual improvements (colour blocks, node icons), PySide6 compatibility, and CI/CD infrastructure.